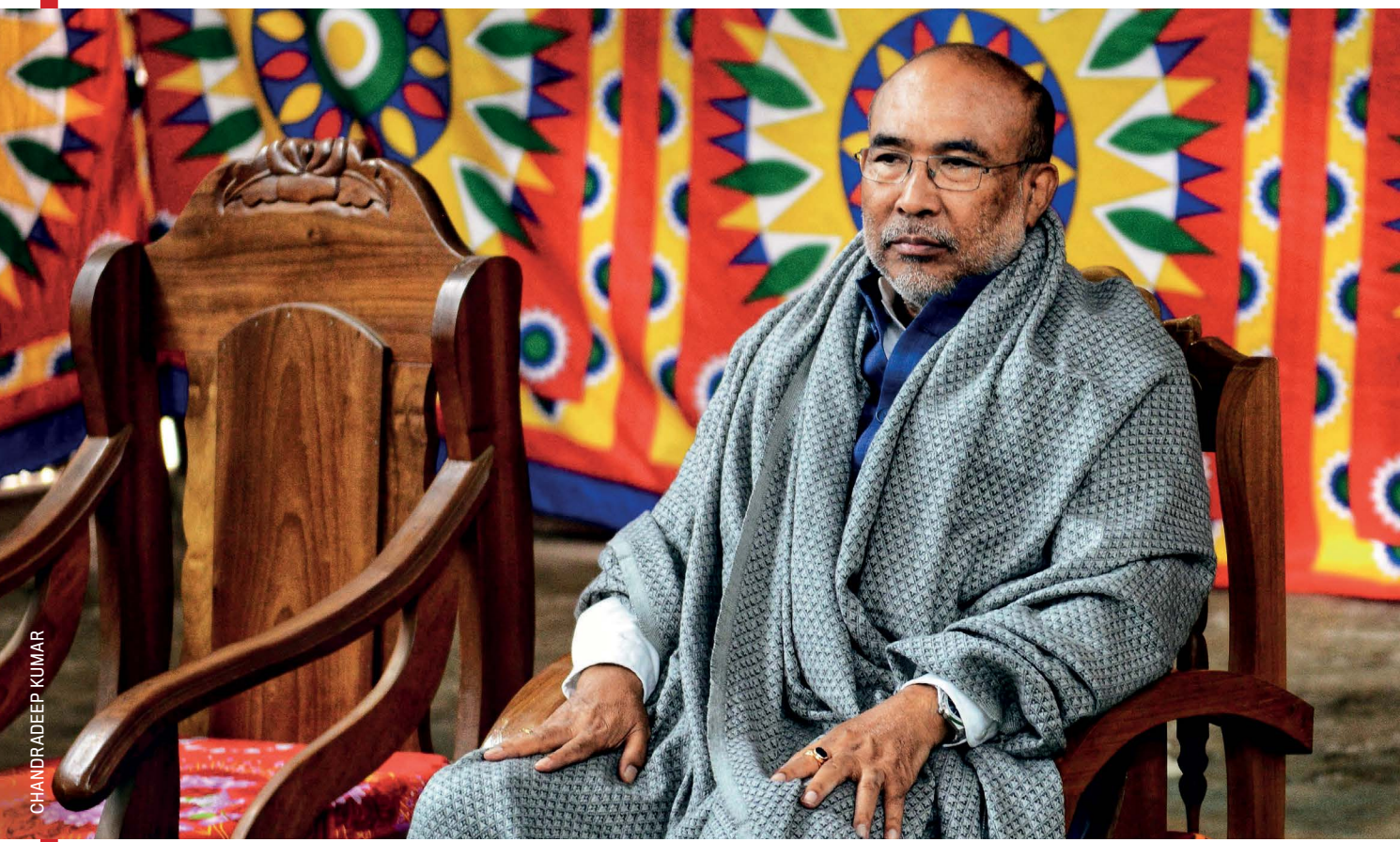
| N. BIREN SINGH | 62 | Chief Minister, Manipur|

Rule of Chaos

THE MANIPUR CM NAVIGATES ETHNIC HOSTILITIES, POLITICAL CHALLENGES, AND A FRACTURED LAW-AND-ORDER LANDSCAPE

By Kaushik Deka



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

IT **IS DIFFICULT TO THINK OF AN EXACT PARALLEL TO MANIPUR CHIEF MINISTER N. BIREN SINGH** in independent India's history. For nearly eight months the state has remained geographically divided along ethnic lines drawn in blood-red hues. There are few signs of either truth or reconciliation: one community is not allowed to live in or even commute to areas inhabited by another. Infractions on this unwritten law can exact a simple, extreme price: the transgressor's life. Even amid the constant smell of cordite in zones where the two sides encountered each other, the smoke rising from places of worship, an anarchic cocktail of militants of sundry stripes and black-shirted vigilante squads, and a depressingly rising body count, a viral video of two women being paraded naked by a group of men seared through the nation's conscience. It was but an X-ray slice of the dystopia Manipur had become